THE CURSED MUSEUM

Every object has a story. None of them can be trusted.

A shared, explorable museum of haunted objects and unreliable histories.

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Design intent: eerie + elegant + vintage + absurdly playful; never gore, cheap horror, or a generic social feed.



Visual references are screenshot crops for style direction, not licensed production artwork.

01 / North star

The Cursed Museum is a live, persistent, multi-user narrative exploration experience. Visitors physically explore thematic galleries, discover strange exhibits, donate new relics, fabricate or contradict archival accounts, and judge the reliability of other visitors' claims. The shared museum evolves between visits.

What "good" means

- Exploration feels like entering a coherent, crowded gothic museum rather than browsing cards.
- A stranger can move, inspect a relic and make a meaningful contribution without instructions.
- Other visitors' movements and contributions appear live; historical records survive refreshes, restarts and redeploys.
- Contradictions are creative material, not accidental data loss: all versions remain discoverable.
- The art, dossier language, voting, and gallery layouts tell one consistent story.

Design principles

- Atmosphere first, legibility always: visual clutter is intentional but actionable hotspots remain obvious.
- Every relic has provenance: author, time, version, and current verdict.
- No automatic destructive overwriting. "Rewrite" is a new competing account or proposed correction.
- Core actions work in both camera views; player control must not be trapped by text-input focus.
- No simulated multiplayer: separate browsers must see the same authoritative shared state.

Audience & success

For small groups of curious visitors who enjoy collaborative storytelling, subtle unease and mischievous evidence-making. Success is observable: two visitors can explore the same hall, see each other, donate a relic, dispute its provenance, vote, and return later to find the archive intact.

02 / Visual identity

Art direction: Gothic Cabinet of Curiosities, Victorian wunderkammer, warm amber light in deep shadow, aged documents, carved dark wood, crowded taxidermy, intricate gilt frames, porcelain, glass, dust, and subtle supernatural anomalies.

Role	Hex	Use
Obsidian	#11100F	Deepest backgrounds
Mahogany	#35251C	Architecture and wood
Antique brass	#88653D	Ornaments and metal
Old gold	#C6A16B	Highlights and interaction
Parchment	#E9DDC5	Text and dossiers
Dried rose	#663D43	Disputes and warnings

Typography: expressive serif display (Cinzel / Cormorant Garamond) for titles and brass nameplates; accessible neutral sans-serif for forms, interaction prompts and long archival records. Use proper font licensing or reliable system fallbacks.

Lighting: warm practical lamps, glowing cases, rim highlights; avoid uniform brightness. Use readable contrast for dossier overlays and keyboard focus. Motion: restrained, slow breathing glow, dust particles, minimal camera sway; reduced-motion setting.

Existing screenshot-derived reference boards



Reference B: overloaded curiosity cabinet, miniature objects, sculptural arrangement, framing and theatrical warm light.



Reference C: framed portrait, ambiguous presence, almost believable haunting.

03 / Dual camera exploration

Two camera modes, one world. A: diagonal overhead/isometric-like third-person navigation for spatial awareness. C: freely movable first-person perspective for close inspection. Press V to switch in place, keeping position, facing, collision and authoritative shared-room state. The character appears in A; the world appears from the character's eyes in C.

Control	Behavior
W / A / S / D or arrows	Move; normalize diagonal speed
Mouse	Click a hotspot; in first person optionally look/turn
E	Interact with nearest focused relic
V	Switch A and C without teleportation
Esc	Close dossier/menu; restore exploration focus
Enter / submit	Submit archival form without triggering movement
Tab	Keyboard navigable overlay controls

World model

- One common set of gallery geometry, exhibit anchors, interactive hotspots, collision and player transforms.
- A camera rig with third-person perspective and first-person configuration; camera wall-occlusion and first-person clipping guards.
- Floor navigation, doors and transitions backed by gallery IDs; each artifact has room ID and showcase/slot ID.
- Pointer picking should resolve to the same exhibit ID in both modes; interaction range is enforced.
- Network packets broadcast room, position, orientation and presence; interpolate remote avatars and handle disconnects.

Important feasibility note

A genuine freely moving first-person camera cannot be supplied by cropping a fixed 2D museum painting. Use an actual lightweight 3D world (e.g. Three.js or React Three Fiber) with authored original textures/props and two camera rigs. Keep dense aesthetic via modular geometry, lighting, decals and collectible display meshes. Confirm browser/device performance on the target Fly deployment.

04 / Exhibition architecture

Gallery	Theme	Objects / staging
I. The Portraits That Watch	Ambiguous portraits and identities	Oil paintings, mirrors, frames on crowded walls
II. Objects That Remember	Recollections and impossible provenance	Silverware, keys, watches, letters on tables
III. The Cabinet of Impossible Life	Unreliable natural history	Bones, jars, fossils, specimens in vitrines
IV. The Forgotten Childhood	Unsettling toys and fairy tales	Dolls, puppets, music boxes, books on shelves

Every room should have entrance/exit, readable sign, at least one interactive display, spatial audio ambience (optional), distinct palette accents, collision boundaries and enough decorative density to feel inhabited. Future community donations are placed into validated, available display slots; if slots are full, extend curated display areas or provide a browsable archive rather than stacking objects on top of one another.



Room staging notes

- Hall: orientation, visitor arrival, shared presence, welcoming but unsettling desk and donor counter.
- Portrait room: layered frames, wall-mounted labels, lights that subtly change as one approaches.
- Curiosity room: tables at variable heights, packed glass cupboards, interactable curios among background props.
- Specimen room: jars, cabinets, handwritten taxonomy, plants and impossibly assembled skeletons.
- Childhood room: music boxes, toys, velvet display stands, silhouettes, delicate eerie lighting.

05 / Core loops and UI

The visitor journey

Enter under a display name → spawn in the Entrance Hall → explore via WASD → notice glinting artifact → approach/click or press E → read artifact dossier → vote, contribute an account or challenge provenance → return to world → discover that other visitors changed the archive.

Donate a Relic

At the donation counter choose gallery, artifact category, name, one-sentence curse, donor display name, and a free valid exhibition slot. A gallery-specific original object illustration / curated model is selected automatically (optional user-supplied image only if the implementation safely supports uploads). Server validates input, persists item, broadcasts artifact-added event. No required AI image generation.

Inspect a Relic

An ornate paper/metal dossier overlays the world: exhibit number, visual, title, category, donor, origin claim, curse level, competing accounts, activity history, votes and writing actions. Overlay should remain readable on mobile and keyboard usable; ESC returns to game without losing position.

Rewrite history

New contributions are explicitly labeled as Original Account, New Testimony, Contradiction, Proposed Revision, or Counter-Evidence. A contributor may challenge any existing account. Publishing never destroys a prior record; preserve immutable account versions and connect challengedAccountId to the conflicting claim. A curated “currently accepted” account can change based on well-defined votes, but older accepted states remain in the audit log.

Verdicts

Each account gets a single active vote per stable visitor identity: Believable, Suspicious or Definitely Cursed. Permit vote change rather than duplicate votes. Show counts and a clearly explained outcome, with ties displayed as Disputed; avoid presenting crowd popularity as factual truth. Curse Level derives from defined vote aggregation (and can be “Unclassified” with no votes). All sessions receive vote changes promptly.

06 / Exhibit dossier — visual and data contract



EXHIBIT #001 | THE SPOON THAT REMEMBERS

Donated by Anonymous Curator. “An ordinary silver spoon that remembers every secret told during dinner.” Gallery II · Objects That Remember. Current classification: DISPUTED. Accounts: 4.

Illustrative conflicting accounts

Original account / 1892: “The spoon was discovered in a boarding house in London.”

Contradiction / 1987: “Manufacturing records identify a later origin; the 1892 archive was apparently signed by a person not yet born.”

Each account block exposes author display name, timestamp, version, relation to earlier evidence, status, vote breakdown, and an Add Counter-Evidence action.

Primary domain tables

Entity	Suggested fields
visitors	id, display_name, session_token_hash, created_at, last_seen
galleries	id, name, description, order
display_slots	id, gallery_id, transform, occupied_exhibit_id
exhibits	id, gallery_id, slot_id, title, type, summary, donor_id, created_at
accounts	id, exhibit_id, parent_id, kind, body, author_id, created_at
votes	id, account_id, visitor_id, verdict, updated_at
events / audit	id, actor_id, event_type, payload, created_at

Use server-side constraints and transactions for slot collisions, duplicate votes and archival changes. If “editing” text is desired, store a new revision rather than mutating the original. Do not persist high-frequency movement samples as permanent archive records.

07 / Realtime multiplayer and persistence

Suggested stack for evaluation: Astro (documents/server endpoints), Three.js (interactive scene and camera rigs), Node server / WebSocket (presence, positions, room events), SQLite (durable artifacts, accounts, votes), Fly deployment with persistent volume. Claude Code may use an equally coherent alternative if it explains the decision in an ADR. A prototype scene must not substitute fake simulated players for tested multi-user behavior.

Data flow

Player client	Server authority	Database / push
Move avatar	Validate / relay bounded positions	WebSocket presence, not every tick persisted
Submit exhibit	Validate gallery + slot; transaction	SQLite commit then broadcast
Create contradiction	Validate target + append account	SQLite commit then broadcast
Cast vote	Upsert per account and visitor	SQLite commit then broadcast result
Enter gallery	Authorize / join room	Send current presence + artifacts

Event vocabulary

presence.joined, presence.left, visitor.moved, gallery.entered, exhibit.created, account.created, vote.changed, archive.updated. Define payload schemas, ordering/revision numbers, reconnect state hydration and no-loss refresh behavior. Server is authoritative; clients re-fetch state after reconnect.

Safety and ergonomics

- Untrusted user text must be escaped / safely rendered; validate lengths and reject script injection.
- Rate-limit contributions and movement packets, cap input size, and provide report/hide controls for public content.
- Choose consistent pseudonymous visitor identity; no account system required unless needed for stronger vote integrity.
- Focus-aware keyboard handling prevents avatar walking during forms; touch controls / accessible alternative for non-keyboard devices.
- Persistent SQLite volume and migration process; restart/redeploy smoke tests.

08 / Delivery roadmap — one autonomous first pass

Checkpoint	Deliverable	Commit theme
0. Audit	Read repo, course brief, current starter, references; record risks	docs: scope and decision baseline
1. Design	README, DESIGN.md, PLAN.md, ADRs, tests/spec for invariants	docs: product vision and contract
2. World	Museum shell, main hall, four gallery interiors, dual cameras, motion and collision	feat: explorable museum
3. Archive	SQLite migration, exhibit slots, donation, dossier, versioned accounts	feat: persistent relic archive
4. Interaction	Contradictions, voting, curse classification, archives	feat: living histories
5. Multiplayer	WebSocket room presence, avatars, shared events, reconnect	feat: shared real-time museum
6. Finish	Polish visual composition, controls, responsive UI, deployment	feat: finish and deploy
7. Acceptance	Run required checks, 2 browsers + persistence checks, fix observed failures	test: verify integrated experience

Autonomy: build every checkpoint in order without stopping for confirmation. Commit meaningful working changes at checkpoints, not every tiny edit. Avoid whole-repo re-reading and blanket check reruns after each file. Run fast checks at logical milestones and an end-to-end acceptance pass before finishing. If a truly blocking dependency occurs, explain the blocker and deliver the nearest honest working state rather than silently claiming completion.

Acceptance walkthrough

- Open browser A and B with distinct visitors; observe live movement, identity and room changes.
- In A donate a relic into a free display slot; B sees it without manual refresh.
- In B submit a contradictory account; A sees it appear live.
- Vote from both browsers; per-visitor vote uniqueness, ties, change votes and labels behave predictably.
- Switch between A and C while near a relic; maintain exact position, collision and interaction.
- Refresh browser, restart server, and redeploy with attached volume; durable records still exist.
- No essential controls fail when focus is inside an input; layout and interactions remain legible.

09 / Handoff rules & known uncertainties

Prior design decisions

- User explicitly wants the full complete creative vision, not a reduced MVP delivered as the final target.
- A and C are both required: diagonal overhead and freely navigable first-person, toggled by V.
- Preserve screenshot-referenced gothic clutter and uncanny portrait character.
- Four thematic galleries, authentic traversal, click-to-inspect, live multi-user presence, donation, competing accounts and verdict voting.
- Use supplied cropped images as references only; create original/licensable production art.
- Agent is authorized to plan and implement full first pass autonomously and commit at material stages.

Course constraints / evidence status

Public Final Project page (checked 14 Oct 2026) describes a full-stack application with persistent backend and agentic workflow; it labels itself DRAFT and says the final brief may change. Week 8 lecture states multi-user, real-time, durable persistence, about one-second updates, one Fly machine/volume, and consistent README, CLAUDE.md and spec/. Verify the latest published final brief against the repository before claiming rubric compliance. Reference: https://comp.anu.edu.au/courses/comp4020-agentic-coding-studio/assessments/final-project/

Technical trade-offs to document

- Dual-camera 3D versus 2.5D painted scenes: coherent world geometry is essential for free first-person movement.
- Original high-quality props / procedural museum staging versus raw screenshots.
- Anonymous identities, voting integrity and moderation under public deployment.
- Server load and asset budgets: dense visuals should not overwhelm typical student laptops.
- No invented claim of “fully tested”: report screenshots, build output and actual two-client results.

What a new chat or Claude Code should do

Read this blueprint first; then current README, DESIGN.md, PLAN.md, active ADRs and repository history. Preserve decisions unless a documented constraint requires revision. Continue from the latest green commit and observed working site, rather than recreating the project from scratch.